

Bespoke PC

GOOD LORDS OF SILICON, I'm not going to be harping about the death of PC like the average ICT analyst. We're still decades away from that happening. In fact, most enthusiast sectors are seeing growth as the overall PC industry declines by 1-1.5 percent each year. So yeah, there's still time before I start getting nightmares. It's the growth that I'm more interested in. Despite every analyst worth their salt having predicted otherwise, the enthusiast segment continues to defy them. The simple reason is that you get exactly what you want with a PC, provided you assemble it, of course.

Fulfilling the need of the consumer has always been the basis of establishment for most businesses. Greed and exploitation soon took over and we started getting perhaps, 80-90 percent of what we wanted from these companies but never 100 percent. That's why a customised solution that you've taken the pain to build still continues to be the driving factor for the PCMASTERRACE. It's my money, I want the best that it can buy. If companies are going to short-change me by giving something of an inferior quality or components that fall short of giving me the performance that I need. Enthusiasts, like yours truly, have the know-how and the means to get our way. Which is why companies can't get away with peddling us sub-par hardware.

Thankfully, they've wisened up and have begun to understand the changing scenario of the enthusiast market. As a result, we now see much shorter product iteration cycles. Did Intel just launch a new series of CPUs for laptops? You'll see all gaming laptops get upgraded to the new CPUs in under two months. Did Qualcomm release a new SoC? You'll see a new OnePlus device come out featuring just that in a month or so after launch. And this is about getting the best hardware possible. Sometimes, you want to customise the device further. Take gaming laptops for example. Most ship with IPS panels in a certain model. If you want a different panel, then you'd have to pick a higher model and that would throw your budget out of whack.

Not anymore. We've already started seeing options wherein the entire configuration

remains the same but just the panels are switched out. So if you want a 120 Hz panel for competitive FPS games, then you'll get a model that gives you just that. And if you're kind of the laid back gamer who likes to watch more movies then you're better off with a VA or IPS panel. Guess what, you can get the exact same configuration with an IPS panel too.

Don't mistake this for modularity. No, that philosophy does not work in the finished goods segment. We've seen plenty of devices which have offered modularity but haven't taken off. It's mostly because the modular components end up being prohibitively expensive. Only when modularity becomes economical will it take off. Cheapness sells, always. So the next decade will see more of these finished goods offering you variants in which just one or two components might be different. For example, if you like the way a certain mouse feels in your hands, then you'll have options for the sensor, or you may have options for the texture. Soon enough, you'll have boutique websites that allow you to customise before you finish your purchase. Dell used to do that with their laptops back in the day. The process took a while but you got what you wanted.

Right now, we're seeing this phenomenon of choice being offered in the pricey segment. Soon enough, as sales volume for these customisable options go up, we'll see the prices drop naturally. Moreover, if we wait long enough, then the concept of modularity will slowly become viable to the extent that getting a customised product is as easy as stepping into a store and keying in your preferences in a kiosk. Wait a few minutes and your customised PC / peripheral will be ready for pick-up. I'm looking forward to the day because with each passing year, we're seeing more of the big enterprises across the world stepping onto Indian soils. That's more competition and that's fuel for innovation. **d**



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